

Research Seminar

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Final Paper

**Title: Recent Foreign-Labor Reforms and the Limits of Social Incorporation in
Japan, 2019-2026**

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Introduction

Japan's foreign-labor policy has entered a new phase since the introduction of the Specified Skilled Worker system (特定技能制度) in 2019. For decades, Japan officially avoided presenting itself as an immigration country, even while admitting foreign labor through indirect channels such as the Technical Intern Training Program (技能実習制度), student work, and Nikkei migration^{1 2}. Recent reforms appear to move beyond this older model by creating more explicit labor-status categories, restructuring the Technical Intern Training Program through Employment for Skill Development (育成就労), and expanding coexistence-related support policies. However, the central issue is whether this reform process represents deeper social incorporation, or whether it mainly reorganizes foreign labor into a more formal and administratively manageable system.

This paper examines Japan's recent foreign-labor reforms from 2019 to 2026. The Technical Intern Training Program is used as the baseline because it represents an older model of managed labor admission: foreign workers were formally accepted under a training and international-contribution framework, while in practice they often supplied labor to sectors facing shortages³. By contrast, the Specified Skilled Worker system formally recognizes foreign nationals as workers in designated sectors. This shift is important, but it should not be treated automatically as full incorporation, because formal labor recognition may still coexist with conditional mobility, temporary residence, family restrictions, and status vulnerability. As Oishi (2020) argues, the recent reform was made

¹ Glenda S ROBERTS, "An Immigration Policy by Any Other Name: Semantics of Immigration to Japan," *Social Science Japan Journal* 21, no. 1 (2018): 89–102, <https://ideas.repec.org/a/oup/sscijp/v21y2018i1p89-102..html>.

² Daisuke Wakisaka, "Unraveling Migration Policy-Making in the Land of 'No Immigrants': Japanese Bureaucracy and the Discursive Gap," *International Migration Review* 58, no. 3 (June 6, 2023): 019791832311715-019791832311715, <https://doi.org/10.1177/01979183231171557>.

³ Hironori Onuki, "Informalization and Temporary Labor Migration: Rethinking Japan's Technical Intern Training Program from a Denationalized View," *Critical Sociology*, November 9, 2023, <https://doi.org/10.1177/08969205231209535>.

possible partly through the redefinition of skill, which allowed Japan to expand labor admission while preserving a politically acceptable policy frame⁴.

The research question is: to what extent have Japan's recent foreign-labor reforms strengthened substantive social incorporation compared with the Technical Intern Training Program baseline, and to what extent have they mainly expanded functional support and administrative management? This paper answers the question through a qualitative policy-evaluation framework. Recent reforms are treated as policy changes from the TITP baseline, while social incorporation is evaluated through four dimensions: labor mobility, residence stability, family and long-term life, and civic or status security. The argument is that Japan's recent reforms represent a real but uneven shift. They improve formal labor recognition, institutional pathways, and support infrastructure, but they remain limited by selective access to long-term residence, restrictions on family life, and a continuing emphasis on administrative governability.

The paper proceeds in four steps. First, it reviews the literature on Japan's managed labor migration and defines social incorporation as a multidimensional concept. Second, it explains the policy background by comparing the Technical Intern Training Program with the Specified Skilled Worker system, Employment for Skill Development, and coexistence-related reforms. Third, it evaluates these reforms across the four dimensions of incorporation. Finally, it argues that Japan's recent reforms should be understood as managed formalization: they move beyond the older training-based model, but they do not yet amount to full social incorporation.

Literature Review and Conceptual Framework

Existing literature on Japan's migration policy has often emphasized the gap between official non-immigration discourse and the practical admission of foreign labor. Roberts (2018) argues that Japanese policymakers have avoided the term *imin*, or

⁴ Nana Oishi, "Skilled or Unskilled?: The Reconfiguration of Migration Policies in Japan," *Journal of Ethnic and Migration Studies* 47, no. 10 (March 27, 2020): 1–18, <https://doi.org/10.1080/1369183x.2020.1731984>.

immigration⁵, while still admitting foreign nationals through alternative categories. Wakisaka (2023) develops this point institutionally by arguing that bureaucratic compartmentalization encouraged temporary and administratively manageable solutions rather than comprehensive immigration reform⁶. Takaya (2025) similarly shows that the 2018 reform was legitimized through discourses such as “foreign human resources,” “competition for human resources,” and “not an immigration policy⁷.” These studies are useful because they suggest that Japan’s recent reforms should not be read simply as a sudden move from closure to openness. Rather, they show a longer pattern in which labor admission is expanded while the political and administrative meaning of immigration remains carefully controlled.

The Technical Intern Training Program (TITP) provides the key baseline for evaluating this pattern. Although TITP was officially framed as a scheme for skills transfer and international contribution, scholars have long criticized it as a de facto temporary labor-migration system. Hamaguchi (2019) shows that the program developed through legal and administrative compromise, while still limiting workers’ ability to change employers⁸. Onuki (2023) goes further by arguing that TITP produced precarious labor relations through informalization and intermediary control in both sending and receiving countries⁹. In this literature, TITP is not merely a flawed training program; it represents an older model

⁵ Glenda S ROBERTS, “An Immigration Policy by Any Other Name: Semantics of Immigration to Japan,” *Social Science Japan Journal* 21, no. 1 (2018): 89–102, <https://ideas.repec.org/a/oup/sscijp/v21y2018i1p89-102..html>.

⁶ Daisuke Wakisaka, “Unraveling Migration Policy-Making in the Land of ‘No Immigrants’: Japanese Bureaucracy and the Discursive Gap,” *International Migration Review* 58, no. 3 (June 6, 2023): 019791832311715-019791832311715, <https://doi.org/10.1177/01979183231171557>.

⁷ Sachi Takaya, “なぜ移民政策が確立されないのか——日本における移民をめぐる政治とリベラル・トリレンマ(Why Hasn’t Established the Official Migration Policy? Migration Politics and Liberal Trilemma in Japan),” *Social Theory and Dynamics* 10 (2017): 58–77, https://doi.org/10.5112/istd.10.0_58.

⁸ Keiichiro Hamaguchi, “How Have Japanese Policies Changed in Accepting Foreign Workers?,” *Japan Labor Issues* 3, no. 14 (2019): 2–7, <https://www.jil.go.jp/english/jli/documents/2019/014-01.pdf>.

⁹ Hironori Onuki, “Informalization and Temporary Labor Migration: Rethinking Japan’s Technical Intern Training Program from a Denationalized View,” *Critical Sociology*, November 9, 2023, <https://doi.org/10.1177/08969205231209535>.

of managed labor admission in which foreign workers were economically necessary but legally and socially positioned as temporary, dependent, and weakly incorporated.

The Specified Skilled Worker system and related reforms mark an important change from this baseline, but the literature warns against treating this change as simple liberalization. Oishi (2020) argues that the 2018 reform became possible through the reconfiguration of “skill,” allowing Japan to admit workers in sectors previously treated as unskilled or semi-skilled while preserving an acceptable skilled-migration framework¹⁰. Higuchi (2025) describes the new migration policy as a form of neoliberal meritocracy: migrants may improve their legal status, but only by passing selective hurdles, while the state provides limited support for meeting those demands. Chiavacci (2025) calls the 2018 reform a “dam break” because it opened a more explicit front door for lower-qualified foreign workers, but he also emphasizes the continued importance of quotas, executive control, and selective settlement pathways¹¹. These arguments suggest that the SSW system should be understood as managed formalization rather than full incorporation.

To evaluate the limits of this managed formalization, this paper uses the concept of social incorporation. Social incorporation is not treated as identical to coexistence assistance, consultation services, or language support. Kondo and Yamawaki’s MIPEX-based discussion shows that integration should be assessed across multiple dimensions, including labor-market mobility, family reunification, education, health care, permanent residence, access to nationality, political participation, and anti-discrimination measures¹². Kashiwazaki’s concept of “incorporating immigrants as foreigners” is especially useful because it shows that migrants may be administratively supported while still not being incorporated as full social members¹³. OECD’s review of Japan also suggests that labor-

¹⁰ Nana Oishi, “Skilled or Unskilled?: The Reconfiguration of Migration Policies in Japan,” *Journal of Ethnic and Migration Studies* 47, no. 10 (March 27, 2020): 1–18, <https://doi.org/10.1080/1369183x.2020.1731984>.

¹¹ David Chiavacci, “Dam Break in Japan’s Immigration Policy: The 2018 Reform in a Long-Term Perspective,” *Social Science Japan Journal* 28, no. 1 (2025): 65–79, <https://doi.org/10.1093/ssjj/jyae033>.

¹² Kondo Atsushi and Keizo Yamawaki, “MIPEX and Japan: Findings and Reflections,” *OMNES* 4, no. 2 (January 31, 2014), <https://doi.org/10.15685/omnes.2014.01.4.2.59>.

¹³ Chikako Kashiwazaki, “Incorporating Immigrants as Foreigners: Multicultural Politics in Japan,” *Citizenship Studies* 17, no. 1 (February 2013): 31–47, <https://doi.org/10.1080/13621025.2013.764216>.

migration governance has developed more clearly than integration policy, reinforcing the need to distinguish labor admission from social incorporation¹⁴.

Taken together, the literature suggests that Japan's recent foreign-labor reforms sit between two different interpretations. On one hand, the shift from TITP-style training logic to the SSW system indicates a real movement toward formal labor recognition and more structured admission channels. On the other hand, studies on skill redefinition, bureaucratic control, and selective status upgrading suggest that this formalization remains strongly conditional and administratively managed. At the same time, integration literature warns that support services, consultation systems, and coexistence policies should not be equated with full incorporation unless they also expand residence security, family life, labor autonomy, anti-discrimination protection, and civic membership. The main gap, therefore, is not whether Japan has become more open to foreign labor, but how far recent reforms alter the social position of foreign workers after admission.

Policy Background: From Technical Intern Training to Formalized Labor Governance

The policy background of this paper begins with the Technical Intern Training Program (技能実習制度), which became one of Japan's most important channels for accepting lower- and medium-skilled foreign workers. The program was formally designed as a system for skills transfer and international contribution, but in practice it supplied labor to sectors facing chronic shortages, including agriculture, construction, manufacturing, food processing, and care-related work. Its institutional logic was therefore ambiguous: foreign nationals were admitted as trainees rather than as ordinary labor migrants, even though their work often met real labor-market demand. This ambiguity made the Technical Intern Training Program a useful baseline for evaluating recent reforms because it

¹⁴ OECD, "Recruiting Immigrant Workers: Japan 2024," OECD, June 30, 2024, https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/recruiting-immigrant-workers-japan-2024_0e5a10e3-en.html.

combined economic dependence on foreign labor with temporary status, employer dependence, and administrative control^{15 16}.

The first major shift in the recent period was the creation of the Specified Skilled Worker system (特定技能制度), which began in 2019 after the 2018 revision of the Immigration Control and Refugee Recognition Act. Unlike the Technical Intern Training Program, the Specified Skilled Worker system openly recognizes foreign nationals as workers in designated sectors facing labor shortages. Specified Skilled Worker (i) allows foreign workers with a certain level of skill and Japanese-language ability to work in approved fields, but it is limited to a maximum stay of five years and generally does not allow family accompaniment. Specified Skilled Worker (ii), by contrast, is designed for workers with more advanced skills, has no fixed upper limit on renewed stays, and allows family accompaniment. This two-tier structure is important because it creates a more explicit labor-status framework while still differentiating sharply between temporary labor presence and more stable residence^{17 18}.

The second major policy development is the planned transition from the Technical Intern Training Program to the Employment for Skill Development system (育成就労制度). The reform was enacted through the 2024 amendment to immigration and technical-intern legislation and is scheduled to become operational on April 1, 2027. Its stated purpose is to develop workers who can move toward the level required for Specified Skilled Worker (i), usually through employment and training in Japan over a three-year

¹⁵ Keiichiro Hamaguchi, “How Have Japanese Policies Changed in Accepting Foreign Workers?,” *Japan Labor Issues* 3, no. 14 (2019): 2–7, <https://www.jil.go.jp/english/jli/documents/2019/014-01.pdf>.

¹⁶ Hironori Onuki, “Informalization and Temporary Labor Migration: Rethinking Japan’s Technical Intern Training Program from a Denationalized View,” *Critical Sociology*, November 9, 2023, <https://doi.org/10.1177/08969205231209535>.

¹⁷ Nana Oishi, “Skilled or Unskilled?: The Reconfiguration of Migration Policies in Japan,” *Journal of Ethnic and Migration Studies* 47, no. 10 (March 27, 2020): 1–18, <https://doi.org/10.1080/1369183x.2020.1731984>.

¹⁸ OECD, “Recruiting Immigrant Workers: Japan 2024,” OECD, June 30, 2024, https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/recruiting-immigrant-workers-japan-2024_0e5a10e3-en.html.

period. Compared with the older Technical Intern Training Program, this reform is important because it more clearly connects initial labor admission, skills development, and the Specified Skilled Worker pathway. However, because the system has been enacted but does not become operational until April 1, 2027, it falls outside the implemented period covered by this paper and is therefore analyzed in terms of its institutional design and anticipated implications rather than as a settled policy outcome¹⁹.

The third policy area is the expansion of coexistence-related governance. In 2022, the Japanese government adopted the Roadmap for the Realization of a Society of Harmonious Coexistence with Foreign Nationals, which set policy goals in areas such as Japanese-language education, information access, consultation services, medical care, education, employment environments, and cooperation between national and local authorities. The Roadmap is important because it shows that Japan's foreign-resident policy is no longer limited to entry control and labor allocation. It also includes support for daily life and local coexistence. At the same time, the Roadmap links coexistence with residency management, institutional coordination, and the proper operation of systems for accepting foreign nationals²⁰.

This governance direction became more visible in 2025–2026 through the creation of the Cabinet Secretariat's Office for a Society of Well-Ordered and Harmonious Coexistence with Foreign Nationals (外国人との秩序ある共生社会推進室). The office was established to act as a central coordinating body for foreign-national policy, and the government held ministerial meetings in 2025 and 2026 to promote comprehensive measures for acceptance and “well-ordered coexistence.” This recent development matters because it shows that Japan's foreign-labor policy is becoming more institutionally

¹⁹ Immigration Services Agency of Japan, “出入国管理及び難民認定法及び外国人の技能実習の適正な実施及び技能実習生の保護に関する法律の一部を改正する法律案 (Bill to Amend the Immigration Control and Refugee Recognition Act and the Act on the Proper Implementation of Technical Intern Training for Foreign Nationals and the Protection of Technical Intern Trainees),” Moj.go.jp, 2024, https://www.moj.go.jp/isa/05_00042.html.

²⁰ Ministerial Conference on Acceptance and Coexistence of Foreign Nationals, “Roadmap for the Realization of a Society of Harmonious Coexistence with Foreign Nationals,” 2022, <https://www.moj.go.jp/isa/content/001404420.pdf>.

coordinated. However, the official language also places coexistence alongside order, compliance, and proper management. Therefore, the policy background to this paper is not simply a movement from exclusion to inclusion. It is a movement from indirect labor admission toward a more formal, coordinated, and status-based system of foreign-labor governance.

Methodology

This paper uses a qualitative policy-evaluation framework to assess whether Japan's recent foreign-labor reforms strengthen social incorporation compared with the Technical Intern Training Program baseline. The method is not designed to measure causal effects statistically. Instead, it evaluates the formal design and likely incorporation implications of recent policy changes by comparing them with the older TITP-style model of managed labor admission. This approach is appropriate because several of the relevant reforms, especially Employment for Skill Development (育成就労), are still in the transition stage. Therefore, the paper evaluates both implemented reforms and reform direction, while avoiding claims that cannot yet be supported by outcome data.

The evaluation is organized around three policy-change packages. The first is the labor-status reform package, including the shift from the Technical Intern Training Program toward Employment for Skill Development and the Specified Skilled Worker pathway. The second is the coexistence and administrative-governance package, including the 2022 Roadmap for the Realization of a Society of Harmonious Coexistence with Foreign Nationals and later “well-ordered coexistence” initiatives. The third is the sectoral allocation and field-expansion package, including the expansion of SSW fields and expected acceptance numbers. These packages are evaluated against four dimensions of social incorporation: labor mobility and workplace autonomy, residence stability and long-term pathways, family and long-term life, and civic incorporation or status security.

The evidence used in this paper comes from official policy documents, government guidelines, academic literature, and survey-based materials. Official documents are used to identify the formal rules of each reform, including status categories, transfer rules,

family-accompaniment conditions, support obligations, and sectoral eligibility. Academic literature is used to interpret these reforms within Japan’s broader migration-governance pattern. OECD 2024 and MIPEx-related literature are used as external reference points for evaluating integration and incorporation. The Basic Survey on Foreign Residents is used cautiously as evidence on foreign residents’ experiences, but it is not treated as sufficient proof of successful incorporation. High satisfaction scores, for example, must be compared with more specific indicators such as workplace problems, housing, language access, discrimination, family separation, and status insecurity.

The following matrix summarizes the evaluation framework used in the analysis.

Policy package	Main policy change	Main incorporation dimensions evaluated
Labor-status reform	TITP → Employment for Skill Development → SSW(i)/SSW(ii)	Labor mobility, residence pathway, family life, status security
Coexistence/governance	Roadmap, consultation, multilingual support, well-ordered coexistence	Functional support, civic/status security, administrative management
Sectoral allocation	SSW field expansion and acceptance numbers	Worker choice, field lock-in, access to SSW(ii)

Table 1. Evaluation Framework²¹.

The matrix does not assume that all reforms are either successful or unsuccessful. Instead, it separates different dimensions of incorporation so that each reform can be evaluated more precisely. A reform may improve functional support while doing little for family life, or it may create a formal residence pathway while keeping that pathway selective and difficult to access. This makes it possible to identify where Japan’s recent foreign-labor reforms move beyond the TITP baseline and where they continue to reproduce administrative management.

²¹ A fuller version of the evaluation matrix, including detailed indicators for each dimension, is provided in Appendix A.

Analysis I: Labor Mobility and Workplace Autonomy

From trainee dependence to worker recognition

The first dimension of social incorporation is labor mobility and workplace autonomy. This matters because a foreign worker's ability to leave an abusive employer, search for better conditions, and use consultation mechanisms without losing residence status is a basic condition for stable social membership. Compared with the Technical Intern Training Program, Japan's recent reforms clearly improve the formal recognition of foreign workers. Under the older TITP model, foreign nationals were admitted as trainees under a skill-transfer framework, even when they were filling labor shortages in practice. Because the program was organized around training plans, supervising organizations, and designated implementing organizations, workers' autonomy was structurally limited. OECD's 2024 review notes that, due to the program's training focus, mobility between employers was expected only in exceptional circumstances, and that restricted mobility created risks of exploitation²². Onuki's analysis similarly shows that TITP vulnerability was not only a result of individual employer misconduct, but also of a broader system of intermediary control, debt, and dependency²³. In this sense, the problem of TITP was not simply that some workplaces were abusive; the problem was that workers had weak exit options.

The Specified Skilled Worker system represents a partial improvement because it formally recognizes foreign nationals as workers rather than trainees. SSW workers are employed under labor contracts and are expected to receive wages equal to or higher than Japanese workers doing the same work. More importantly for mobility, official SSW guidance states that workers can change jobs within the same industrial field, and that they

²² OECD. "Recruiting Immigrant Workers: Japan 2024." OECD, June 30, 2024.
https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/recruiting-immigrant-workers-japan-2024_0e5a10e3-en.html.

²³ Hironori Onuki. "Informalization and Temporary Labor Migration: Rethinking Japan's Technical Intern Training Program From a Denationalized View." *Critical Sociology*, November 9, 2023.
<https://doi.org/10.1177/08969205231209535>.

can move to another field if they pass the required skill test for that field²⁴. This is a meaningful change from the TITP baseline because it gives workers a clearer formal right to quit one employer and move to another accepting organization. It also means that labor mobility is no longer treated only as an exception caused by workplace collapse or unavoidable circumstances.

Conditional mobility under SSW and Employment for Skill Development

However, the improvement should not be overstated. SSW mobility is still conditional because it is tied to status categories, approved fields, skill tests, and the availability of a new accepting organization. Workers are not given open access to the general labor market. They must remain within the administrative structure of the SSW system, and changing employers requires procedural compliance, including notification to immigration authorities after contract termination. The system therefore expands mobility, but only within a regulated labor-allocation framework. OECD's review describes Japan's labor-migration system as employer-driven because foreign workers generally need a job offer from a Japanese employer, rather than being selected directly by the state as independent labor-market entrants²⁵. This weakens the incorporation effect of SSW: workers are more recognized than under TITP, but their workplace autonomy remains mediated by employers, industry categories, and immigration administration.

The planned Employment for Skill Development system also shows this mixed character. It is designed to replace the Technical Intern Training Program and to develop workers who can reach the level of SSW(i) through employment in Japan. This is a clear shift away from the old language of international contribution and toward a more explicit labor-and-skills pathway. Yet official materials also state that the period of transfer limitation under the new system will be determined in each accepting field, generally

²⁴ Immigration Services Agency of Japan. "Initiatives to Accept New Foreign Nationals and for the Realization of Society of Harmonious Coexistence," May 2026.
<https://www.moj.go.jp/isa/content/930004452.pdf>.

²⁵ OECD, "Recruiting Immigrant Workers: Japan 2024," OECD, June 30, 2024,
https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/recruiting-immigrant-workers-japan-2024_0e5a10e3-en.html.

within a one-to-two-year range²⁶. This suggests that the reform is designed to improve mobility compared with TITP, but that it would not create full worker freedom from the beginning of employment. The enacted design is intended to expand transfer opportunities, but its practical effects cannot yet be assessed. Foreign workers may gain a clearer route to SSW(i), but they still remain inside an administratively designed pipeline.

Workplace autonomy and the problem of enforcement

The importance of mobility becomes clearer when enforcement data are considered. In 2025, the Ministry of Health, Labour and Welfare reported the results of 2024 inspections of workplaces using technical interns and specified skilled workers. Among inspected workplaces using technical interns, labor-standard violations were found in 8,310 of 11,355 workplaces, or 73.2 percent. For workplaces using SSW workers, violations were found in 4,395 of 5,750 inspected workplaces, or 76.4 percent²⁷. These figures should be interpreted carefully because inspections were conducted where legal violations were suspected; they do not mean that the same violation rate applies to all accepting workplaces. Nevertheless, the data are important because they show that formal worker recognition does not automatically guarantee workplace protection. If workers cannot realistically leave, complain, or change employers without fear of losing income or status, then legal recognition remains incomplete.

Therefore, in terms of labor mobility and workplace autonomy, recent reforms represent partial incorporation. Compared with TITP, the SSW system already creates stronger formal worker recognition and more visible transfer possibilities, while Employment for Skill Development is designed to extend the same logic once it becomes

²⁶ Immigration Services Agency of Japan., “Initiatives to Accept New Foreign Nationals and for the Realization of Society of Harmonious Coexistence,” May 2026, <https://www.moj.go.jp/isa/content/930004452.pdf>.

²⁷ Ministry of Health, Labour and Welfare, “外国人技能実習生又は特定技能外国人を使用する事業場 に対して行った 令和 6 年の監督指導、送検等の状況を公表します(Publishing the Details of the Supervision, Guidance, and Prosecution Actions Taken in 2024 against Businesses Employing Foreign Technical Trainees or Specified Skilled Workers.),” Ministry of Health, Labour and Welfare, September 26, 2025, https://www.mhlw.go.jp/stf/newpage_63807.html.

operational. They weaken the older trainee logic and are intended to provide clearer routes for changing employers.

However, mobility remains conditional, field-based, and administratively supervised. The reforms improve workers' position inside the foreign-labor system, but they do not fully detach labor rights from immigration status. Japan has therefore moved beyond the most restrictive TITP-style model, but labor autonomy remains limited by the same broader logic of managed migration²⁸.

Analysis II: Residence Stability, Family Life, and Long-Term Pathways

From temporary rotation to conditional settlement

The second dimension of social incorporation is residence stability and the possibility of building long-term life in Japan. This dimension is especially important because labor recognition alone does not produce incorporation if workers are expected to leave after a fixed period or if they cannot realistically bring family members. Compared with the Technical Intern Training Program, the Specified Skilled Worker system creates a clearer residence pathway. Under TITP, the institutional logic was temporary rotation: workers were admitted for training and skill transfer, not for settlement. Even when they worked in Japan for several years, their status did not provide a stable route to long-term residence. Onuki (2023) therefore describes TITP as a form of temporary labor migration that kept workers economically useful but socially weakly incorporated²⁹.

The SSW system partly changes this structure by creating two levels of labor status. Specified Skilled Worker (i) gives foreign workers a formal labor status for up to five years, while Specified Skilled Worker (ii) allows renewable residence without a fixed upper limit. SSW(ii) also permits family accompaniment, unlike SSW(i), which generally does not

²⁸ Immigration Services Agency of Japan. "Initiatives to Accept New Foreign Nationals and for the Realization of Society of Harmonious Coexistence," May 2026.
<https://www.moj.go.jp/isa/content/930004452.pdf>.

²⁹ Hironori Onuki, "Informalization and Temporary Labor Migration: Rethinking Japan's Technical Intern Training Program from a Denationalized View," *Critical Sociology*, November 9, 2023,
<https://doi.org/10.1177/08969205231209535>.

allow workers to bring family members^{30 31}. This distinction is central to Japan's recent reform. It means that Japan now has a visible institutional route from temporary labor admission toward longer-term residence. In this sense, the reform does go beyond the TITP baseline. Foreign workers are no longer only trainees expected to return after skill transfer; some can theoretically move into a status that supports longer residence and family life.

The limits of SSW(i): residence without settlement

However, SSW(i) itself remains closer to temporary labor admission than to full incorporation. Its maximum total stay is five years, and family accompaniment is generally not allowed. This matters because five years is long enough for workers to become socially and economically embedded in Japan, but not long enough to guarantee a stable future. A worker under SSW(i) may learn Japanese, build workplace experience, pay taxes and social insurance, and develop local ties, yet still remain structurally separated from family reunification and long-term security. The result is a partial form of incorporation: workers are included as laborers, but their family and settlement needs remain institutionally postponed.

Permanent residence rules reinforce this limitation. Japan's 2026 permanent-residence guidelines require, in principle, ten years of continuous residence in Japan, including at least five continuous years under a qualifying work-related or residence status. Time spent under Technical Intern Training and SSW(i) can count toward the ten-year continuous-residence requirement, but it does not count toward the separate five-year qualifying-status requirement³². The ISA SSW Q&A also states that it is difficult to change directly from SSW(i) to permanent residence because the SSW(i) period is limited to five

³⁰ Immigration Services Agency / SSW Support Website, "What Is the 'Specified Skilled Worker' Status of Residence?," Support Website for the Specified Skilled Worker Program | Immigration Services Agency of Japan, n.d., <https://www.ssw.go.jp/en/about/visa/>.

³¹ Ministry of Foreign Affairs of Japan, "What Is the SSW ? | Japan Is Looking for Specified Skilled Workers!," [www.mofa.go.jp](https://www.mofa.go.jp/mofaj/ca/fna/ssw/us/overview/), 2019, <https://www.mofa.go.jp/mofaj/ca/fna/ssw/us/overview/>.

³² Immigration Services Agency of Japan. "Initiatives to Accept New Foreign Nationals and for the Realization of Society of Harmonious Coexistence ," May 2026. <https://www.moj.go.jp/isa/content/930004452.pdf>.

years and does not count as the relevant work-status period, while SSW(ii) can count toward permanent residence eligibility³³. OECD (2024) similarly argues that Japan's permanent-residence requirements are strict compared with many OECD countries, where long-term labor migrants often become eligible after a shorter period. This shows that SSW(i) offers legal residence, but not a secure settlement pathway by itself.

SSW(ii) as selective incorporation

SSW(ii) is therefore the key to long-term incorporation, but access to it remains selective. The government expanded the eligible fields for SSW(ii) in 2023, making it possible in most SSW fields except nursing care, which has a separate care-worker pathway. This expansion strengthened the formal possibility of settlement because more workers can now aim for a status with renewable stay and family accompaniment. Nevertheless, the transition from SSW(i) to SSW(ii) is not automatic. Workers must satisfy higher skill requirements, usually through examinations or equivalent assessment, and they must remain within approved sectoral frameworks. This makes long-term residence dependent on merit-based selection and sectoral demand rather than on social embeddedness alone.

Official residence statistics also show that SSW(ii) remains much smaller than SSW(i). At the end of 2025, there were 390,296 SSW residents in total, but only 7,955 were SSW(ii) residents³⁴. The number is growing, but it still represents a small minority of the overall SSW population. This matters analytically because the existence of SSW(ii) should not be confused with broad incorporation for most foreign workers. The pathway exists, but it remains narrow, skill-filtered, and administratively controlled.

Therefore, in terms of residence stability and family life, Japan's recent reforms represent a clear but limited improvement. They create a more explicit pathway from labor admission to long-term residence than TITP did, especially through SSW(ii). However, the

³³ Immigration Services Agency of Japan, “特定技能制度に関する Q & A (Q&A Regarding the Specified Skilled Worker System),” Moj.go.jp, 2026, <https://www.moj.go.jp/isa/policies/ssw/faq.html>.

³⁴ Immigration Services Agency of Japan. “在留外国人に対する基礎調査(Basic Survey of Foreign Residents).” www.moj.go.jp, 2026. https://www.moj.go.jp/isa/support/coexistence/04_00017.html.

main status used by most workers, SSW(i), remains temporary, family-restrictive, and weak as a direct route to permanent residence. The reform therefore strengthens incorporation only for workers who can pass into the more selective SSW(ii) category. For many others, Japan's system still provides residence for labor contribution without guaranteeing stable settlement or family life.

Analysis III: Functional Support, Civic/Status Security, and Administrative Management

From coexistence support to functional incorporation

The third dimension of social incorporation concerns functional support, civic and status security, and administrative management. Compared with the Technical Intern Training Program baseline, recent coexistence policies represent a clearer expansion of support infrastructure for foreign residents. Under the older TITP model, foreign workers were often treated mainly through training, supervision, and workplace-based management. By contrast, the recent coexistence framework addresses foreign residents more directly as people living in local communities. The 2022 *Roadmap for the Realization of a Society of Harmonious Coexistence with Foreign Nationals* identifies Japanese-language education, multilingual information, consultation services, employment support, medical care, child education, housing, welfare access, and local-government coordination as policy areas necessary for coexistence³⁵. The Ministry of Health, Labour and Welfare also provides multilingual consultation services for foreign workers on labor conditions, including hotline and regional consultation channels³⁶. These measures matter because they can reduce everyday barriers that foreign residents face when trying to work, use public services, access medical care, educate children, or seek help in workplace disputes. In this limited sense, recent reforms strengthen functional incorporation.

³⁵ Ministerial Conference on Acceptance and Coexistence of Foreign Nationals, "Roadmap for the Realization of a Society of Harmonious Coexistence with Foreign Nationals," 2022, <https://www.moj.go.jp/isa/content/001404420.pdf>.

³⁶ Ministry of Health, Labour and Welfare, "相談機関のご紹介(Advisor for Foreign Workers Section)," 2026, <https://www.check-roudou.mhlw.go.jp/soudan/foreigner.html>.

However, functional support should not be treated as equivalent to full social incorporation. The literature on migrant integration emphasizes that incorporation is multidimensional. Kondo and Yamawaki's MIPEX-based discussion evaluates integration through areas such as labor-market mobility, family reunification, education, health care, permanent residence, political participation, access to nationality, and anti-discrimination protection³⁷. From this perspective, consultation services and multilingual information are important, but they only cover part of incorporation. They help foreign residents navigate the system, but they do not necessarily change their position within the system. This distinction is central to the paper's argument: Japan's reforms may improve support without fully expanding membership.

Basic Survey evidence and the limits of satisfaction

The Basic Survey on Foreign Residents should therefore be used as important but limited evidence. The 2025 survey reports that 91.0 percent of respondents were either satisfied or somewhat satisfied with life in Japan³⁸. This suggests that many foreign residents evaluate everyday life in Japan positively, possibly reflecting public safety, clean living environments, transportation convenience, income opportunities, or stable local services. However, high satisfaction does not automatically prove substantive incorporation, because satisfaction may coexist with workplace problems, low wages, family separation, housing discrimination, Japanese-language barriers, or anxiety over residence status.

The satisfaction result also requires methodological caution. Survey research on sensitive questions shows that responses can be affected by nonresponse bias and social desirability bias, especially when respondents are uncertain about how their answers may

³⁷ Kondo Atsushi and Keizo Yamawaki, "MIPEX and Japan: Findings and Reflections," *OMNES* 4, no. 2 (January 31, 2014), <https://doi.org/10.15685/omnes.2014.01.4.2.59>.

³⁸ Immigration Services Agency of Japan, "在留外国人に対する基礎調査(Basic Survey of Foreign Residents)," www.moj.go.jp, 2026, https://www.moj.go.jp/isa/support/coexistence/04_00017.html.

be used³⁹. Even though the government states that survey responses do not affect immigration procedures, some foreign residents may still perceive a power asymmetry, because their legal stay ultimately depends on residence status and immigration administration. This does not mean the reported satisfaction is false. It means that a high satisfaction score produced under these conditions is stronger as evidence of functional living conditions than as evidence of secure membership.

For this reason, the survey should be triangulated with formal policy rules and academic literature rather than treated as final proof of successful incorporation. The same survey reports problems related to living costs, wages, communication difficulties, and discrimination against foreigners⁴⁰. These findings show that everyday satisfaction can coexist with structural vulnerability. Moreover, different residence statuses produce very different experiences: technical interns, Specified Skilled Workers, permanent residents, international students, and spouses of Japanese nationals are not incorporated into Japanese society in the same way, and an aggregate satisfaction figure conceals exactly the status-based differences that this paper's evaluation framework is designed to capture. The Basic Survey is therefore useful evidence on functional living conditions, but it cannot by itself answer whether recent reforms have achieved deeper civic or status incorporation.

Civic/status security and supportive governability

The deeper limitation appears in civic and status security. Japan's recent reforms expand access to consultation and administrative support, but they do not substantially expand political participation, local voting rights, access to nationality, or strong national anti-discrimination protection. Kashiwazaki's concept of "incorporating immigrants as foreigners" is useful here because it shows that immigrants may be supported and managed while still not being treated as full members of society⁴¹. This pattern fits Japan's recent

³⁹ Tourangeau, Roger, and Ting Yan. "Sensitive Questions in Surveys." *Psychological Bulletin* 133, no. 5 (2007): 859–83. <https://doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.133.5.859>.

⁴⁰ *Ibid.*

⁴¹ Chikako Kashiwazaki, "Incorporating Immigrants as Foreigners: Multicultural Politics in Japan," *Citizenship Studies* 17, no. 1 (February 2013): 31–47, <https://doi.org/10.1080/13621025.2013.764216>.

foreign-labor reforms. Foreign residents are increasingly supported as workers, residents, and service users, but their civic position remains limited.

The 2025–2026 well-ordered coexistence phase reinforces this mixed pattern. The Cabinet Secretariat’s Office for a Society of Well-Ordered and Harmonious Coexistence with Foreign Nationals centralizes policy coordination, but the official framework also emphasizes order, proper system operation, entry and residence management, public safety, national health insurance, and unpaid medical costs⁴². This does not mean that the coexistence framework is simply exclusionary. Rather, it shows that support and control are developing together. OECD’s 2024 review similarly notes that Japan has only recently started developing integration policy for labor migrants and that integration into Japanese society remains a challenge⁴³. Therefore, the coexistence package should be understood as a form of supportive governability: foreign residents receive more assistance to live and work in Japan, while the state preserves strong administrative authority over the terms of their membership.

In this sense, Analysis III confirms the paper’s broader argument. Recent reforms improve functional incorporation more clearly than civic or status incorporation. Consultation systems, multilingual information, and local-government coordination make everyday life more manageable for foreign residents. Yet they do not fully resolve deeper issues of political voice, anti-discrimination protection, residence security, and public-order framing. The reforms therefore move beyond the older TITP-style model of weak support, but they still remain within a management-centered migration regime.

Therefore, coexistence policy improves functional support, but the rise of order, compliance, and public-security framing suggests that support is paired with stronger administrative governability rather than fuller civic incorporation.

⁴² Cabinet Secretariat, Government of Japan, “Office for a Society of Well-Ordered and Harmonious Coexistence with Foreign Nationals,” Cas.go.jp, 2025, https://www.cas.go.jp/jp/seisaku/symbiotic_society/en.html.

⁴³ OECD, “Recruiting Immigrant Workers: Japan 2024,” OECD, June 30, 2024, https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/recruiting-immigrant-workers-japan-2024_0e5a10e3-en.html.

Discussion: Partial Incorporation within Managed Migration

Interpreting uneven reform outcomes

The three analysis sections show that Japan's recent foreign-labor reforms are real but uneven. Compared with the Technical Intern Training Program baseline, Japan has moved toward more explicit labor recognition, clearer institutional pathways, and more developed support infrastructure. The Specified Skilled Worker system and Employment for Skill Development weaken the older training-based logic, while coexistence policies expand consultation, multilingual information, and local-government coordination. The reforms therefore should not be dismissed as symbolic. However, the improvement is distributed unevenly across the four dimensions of incorporation: labor mobility is more visible but remains conditional; residence stability improves mainly for the minority who reach SSW(ii); family life remains restricted under SSW(i); and functional support expands more clearly than civic or status security. The reform process narrows the gap between labor admission and social incorporation, but it does not close it. Japan is building a more organized labor-migration regime while preserving strong administrative control, and the overall result is managed formalization rather than full incorporation.

Stratification by design: differential exclusion and selective settlement

The uneven outcomes documented in the three analysis sections should not be read as an accidental gap between policy ambition and implementation. The hierarchy appears to be built into the architecture of the system itself. The core features of the reformed regime all point in the same direction: the five-year ceiling on SSW(i), the general prohibition of family accompaniment under that status, the exclusion of both Technical Intern Training and SSW(i) periods from the work-status calculation for permanent residence, and the skill-test gate controlling entry to SSW(ii). Each feature separates the use of lower-skilled labor from the settlement of lower-skilled workers. In Castles' classic formulation, this is differential exclusion: migrants are incorporated into one sphere of society, the labor market, while being excluded from others, such as family life, long-term

residence, and political membership⁴⁴. Higuchi's account of selection by neoliberal meritocracy describes the same logic in its contemporary Japanese form: status upgrading is formally possible, but only through selective hurdles that individual workers must clear largely on their own⁴⁵. From this perspective, the thinness of incorporation policy for the lower tier is not neglect. The institutional design has a systematically selective effect: incorporation resources concentrate on the tier the system is structured to retain, while the lower tier receives little support toward settlement.

Intent cannot be observed directly, but it can be inferred from design choices that would otherwise be difficult to explain. The exclusion of SSW(i) years from the permanent-residence calculation is an explicit written rule, not an administrative oversight; if the goal of the two-tier system were gradual incorporation, crediting those years would be the natural design. The family-accompaniment prohibition operates during precisely the period when workers are asked to learn Japanese, pass examinations, and invest in Japan. Read historically, the design also preserves the older principle that Japan accepts skilled migrants for settlement while treating unskilled labor as temporary: as Oishi shows, the 2018 reform relocated this boundary by redefining who counts as skilled rather than abandoning selection itself⁴⁶. The two-tier structure thus does not remove the old exclusionary line; it moves the line inside the admission system, where it can be administered through status categories rather than defended at the border.

The strongest objection to this interpretation is that the hierarchy is a staircase rather than a wall: a deliberate sequencing strategy rather than deliberate stratification. On this reading, the Employment for Skill Development → SSW(i) → SSW(ii) pipeline is designed to move workers upward; the 2023 expansion of SSW(ii) fields widened the top

⁴⁴ Castles, Stephen. "How Nation-States Respond to Immigration and Ethnic Diversity." *Journal of Ethnic and Migration Studies* 21, no. 3 (July 1995): 293–308. <https://doi.org/10.1080/1369183x.1995.9976493>.

⁴⁵ Higuchi, Naoto. "What Is New about Japan's New Migration Policy? From Recruitment of 'Nonlabor' Workers to Selection by Neoliberal Meritocracy." *Social Science Japan Journal*, 28, no. 1 (2025). <https://doi.org/10.1093/ssjj/jyae011>.

⁴⁶ Oishi, Nana. "Skilled or Unskilled?: The Reconfiguration of Migration Policies in Japan." *Journal of Ethnic and Migration Studies* 47, no. 10 (March 27, 2020): 1–18. <https://doi.org/10.1080/1369183x.2020.1731984>.

of the staircase; and SSW(ii) numbers, though still small, are growing rapidly from a near-zero base. Conditionality would then reflect prudent incrementalism in a country with fragile public support for immigration, and today's restrictions might be relaxed as the system matures. This objection deserves genuine weight, because the pipeline is real and the reform trajectory since 2019 has consistently moved toward openness rather than closure. Nevertheless, three features of the current design resist the sequencing interpretation. First, a sequencing design would bank workers' time: although SSW(i) years can count toward the ten-year continuous-residence requirement, they are excluded from the separate five-year qualifying-status requirement, so they build little toward permanent residence. Second, a sequencing design would preserve workers' family lives during the transition, yet family separation is imposed for up to five years. Third, even workers who complete the entire staircase arrive not at secure membership but at discretionary renewal under the McLean framework discussed below. The most defensible conclusion is therefore an intermediate one: the current structure is consistent with a model of selective settlement rather than simple sequencing. Its design systematically separates broad, temporary access to lower-skilled employment from far narrower access to long-term settlement..

Political Salience and the Limits of Policy Design

The findings also show that incorporation cannot be evaluated only from the side of policy design. Social incorporation depends not only on migrants' adaptation or on formal rules, but also on whether the receiving society accepts foreign residents as legitimate members. Recent research on Japanese host-society attitudes shows that public opinion toward immigration remains mixed and is often shaped by concerns over culture, public safety, and local community change⁴⁷. The 2025 House of Councillors election made this tension visible at the national level. *Sanseito's* "Japanese First" campaign brought anti-foreigner rhetoric into electoral debate⁴⁸, and a Yomiuri Shimbun analysis of social-

⁴⁷ Katharine Okumura, "Perspectives on Host Society Attitudes toward Immigrants: A Review of Recent Findings from Japan," *Aoyama Journal of International Politics* 113 (2024): 91–112, <https://www.sipec.aoyama.ac.jp/uploads/03/04a046d067f1a5eb4cc3bc20c696a0d2dc0c9207.pdf>.

⁴⁸ Tim Kelly and John Geddie, "'Japanese First' Party Shakes up Election with Alarm over Foreigners," *Reuters*, July 17, 2025, <https://www.reuters.com/world/japanese-first-party-shakes-up-election-with-alarm-over-foreigners-2025-07-16/>.

media posts during the campaign found that the issue of foreign nationals attracted more attention than any other topic, ahead of the consumption tax and benefit payments⁴⁹. Subsequent government discussion of a possible cap on the foreign-resident population further suggests that mobilized political pressure can pull policy back toward numerical control and social-friction management⁵⁰. This dynamic matters for the paper's argument in two ways. First, it shows that public-order framing is not external to migration policy; it shapes the political limits of incorporation. Second, it shows that incorporation gains are fragile and potentially reversible: even where formal policy expands support, political contestation can shrink the political space in which deeper incorporation could develop. Policy design alone therefore cannot guarantee social acceptance.

Sovereign control and conditional membership

Finally, the limits of incorporation reflect the legal structure of migration governance itself. Immigration control is a core function of state sovereignty, and the Immigration Control and Refugee Recognition Act gives the state authority over entry and departure, residence status, renewal, deportation procedures, and special permission to stay. The 1978 McLean judgment remains the constitutional foundation of this structure. The Supreme Court held that foreign nationals are not guaranteed a constitutional right to reside in Japan or to demand continued residence, and that decisions on extending a period of stay are left to the broad discretion of the Minister of Justice⁵¹. The Court further held that

⁴⁹ 読売新聞オンライン (Yomitori News). “参議院選挙:参院選の投稿分析、最も注目集めたのは外国人問題…「消費税」や「給付」が続く (Analysis of Social Media Posts Regarding the Upper House Election Reveals That the Issue of Foreign Nationals Attracted the Most Attention, Followed by ‘Consumption Tax’ and ‘Benefit Payments.’)” 読売新聞. 読売新聞オンライン, August 2025. <https://www.yomiuri.co.jp/election/sangiin/20250801-oyt1t50129/>.

⁵⁰ Mariko Katsumura, “Japan Should Debate Cap for Foreign Residents, Government Report Says,” *Reuters*, August 29, 2025, <https://www.reuters.com/world/japan-should-debate-cap-foreign-residents-government-report-says-2025-08-29/>.

⁵¹ Supreme Court Grand Bench, 在留期間更新不許可処分取消請求事件 (Case seeking annulment of a decision denying extension of period of stay), Courts.go.jp § 民集 32 卷 7 号 1223 頁 (Minshu Vol. 32, No. 7, p. 1223) (Supreme Court Grand Bench 1978).

although constitutional guarantees of political freedom extend in principle to foreign residents, this protection does not bind the state's discretion over residence: activities protected as fundamental rights during a period of stay may still be weighed as negative factors when renewal is decided. This doctrinal point matters for evaluating recent reforms because it defines the ceiling of incorporation. Foreign residents may work, receive expanded support, and build local lives, but even formally protected conduct can carry consequences for their continued stay, which means their membership remains mediated by administrative judgment rather than secured as a right. Support, in other words, does not remove status vulnerability.

Japan's recent reforms should therefore be understood as partial incorporation within managed migration. The state has made foreign-labor admission more explicit and support systems more developed, but it has not transformed foreign workers into secure social members, and the surrounding legal doctrine and political climate limit how far incorporation can currently extend. The Japanese case shows that policy formalization does not automatically equal incorporation: a country can move beyond side-door labor admission while still preserving strong control over family settlement, civic participation, public legitimacy, and long-term membership.

Conclusion

This paper has examined whether Japan's recent foreign-labor reforms from 2019 to 2026 have strengthened substantive social incorporation or mainly reorganized foreign labor through a more formal system of administrative management. The answer is mixed. Compared with the Technical Intern Training Program baseline, the Specified Skilled Worker system, Employment for Skill Development, and coexistence-related policies represent a real policy shift. Foreign workers are now more explicitly recognized as workers, formal pathways from training to labor status have become clearer, and support systems for daily life have expanded.

However, these reforms do not amount to full social incorporation. Labor mobility remains conditional on status categories, designated fields, and administrative procedures. Residence stability improves mainly for workers who can move into SSW(ii), while SSW(i) remains temporary and generally excludes family accompaniment. Coexistence policies provide useful functional support, but they do not fully address civic participation, anti-discrimination protection, public legitimacy, or long-term status security. Survey evidence also suggests that many foreign residents are satisfied with life in Japan, but satisfaction alone cannot prove deeper incorporation.

Therefore, Japan's recent reforms are best understood as managed formalization. They move beyond the older side-door and training-based model, but they preserve strong administrative control over the terms of foreign workers' membership. The Japanese case shows that accepting more foreign workers and creating clearer labor-status categories does not automatically produce social incorporation. The central issue is not only whether Japan admits foreign workers, but what kind of social position they are allowed to occupy after admission. Moreover, the analysis suggests that these limits are not transitional imperfections but design features: the tiered structure institutionally separates broad access to lower-skilled employment from more selective access to family unity and long-term settlement.

Appendix A: Policy-Evaluation Matrix for Recent Foreign-Labor Reforms

Policy package compared with TITP-style baseline	Concrete policy changes included	Overall incorporation implication	Labor mobility / workplace autonomy	Residence stability / long-term pathway	Family and long-term life	Civic incorporation / status security
Labor-status reform package	Shift from TITP-style training logic to a clearer 育成就 劳 → SSW(i) → SSW(ii) pathway. SSW is explicitly a status for working, unlike TITP, which is framed as acquiring skills. SSW(i) allows work for up to five years, while SSW(ii) has no upper stay limit and allows family accompaniment.	Indicators: whether the reform changes migrants from temporary “trainees” into recognized workers with a clearer pathway; whether it remains mainly a labor-supply pipeline.	Indicators: worker-initiated transfer rules under 育成就劳; job-changing rules within SSW; employer dependence; access to complaint/support mechanisms.	Indicators: transition from 育成就 劳 to SSW(i); five-year limit under SSW(i); transition possibility to SSW(ii); renewability; PR possibility.	Indicators: SSW(i) family accompaniment not allowed; SSW(ii) family accompaniment allowed; realistic accessibility of SSW(ii).	Indicators: whether workers can complain, transfer, or seek advice without risking residence status; protection against employer retaliation.
Coexistence and administrative-governance package	Expansion of coexistence/support policy through the 2022 Roadmap and later “well-ordered and harmonious	Indicators: balance between support/inclusion language and order/compliance/monitoring language; whether coexistence means	Indicators: access to labor consultation, rights information, multilingual	Indicators: access to administrative guidance, social insurance	Indicators: child education support, childcare, housing, health care, disaster	Indicators: anti-discrimination measures, local participation,

Policy package compared with TITP-style baseline	Concrete policy changes included	Overall incorporation implication	Labor mobility / workplace autonomy	Residence stability / long-term pathway	Family and long-term life	Civic incorporation / status security
	coexistence” framework. Recent official framing includes support, compliance, proper system operation, and stronger cross-ministerial governance.	incorporation or governability.	guidance, workplace-dispute support independent from employers.	information, education, health care, welfare navigation, local-government support.	information, family consultation, life-cycle support.	political expression, McLean-style vulnerability, public-order framing.
Sectoral allocation / field-expansion package	The 2024 revision reset expected SSW acceptance numbers and expanded covered fields. Following the Cabinet decision of 23 January 2026 and the enforcement of the relevant ministerial ordinances in April 2026, the SSW system covers 19	Indicators: whether field expansion is tied to incorporation capacity or mainly to sectoral labor-shortage management; whether migrants are treated as social members or allocated labor units.	Indicators: number of eligible fields; cross-field transfer possibilities; whether workers are locked into shortage sectors; whether field expansion increases worker choice.	Indicators: whether high-demand fields offer realistic access to SSW(ii); whether field allocation connects to long-term residence pathways.	Indirectly related through differential access to SSW(ii), family accompaniment, and longer-term status security	

Policy package compared with TITP-style baseline	Concrete policy changes included	Overall incorporation implication	Labor mobility / workplace autonomy	Residence stability / long-term pathway	Family and long-term life	Civic incorporation / status security
	designated fields for SSW(i), with actual acceptance in the three newly added fields (linen supply, logistics warehousing, resource circulation) pending completion of skills-testing arrangements, expected around FY2027; SSW(ii) covers 11 fields.					

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